

greeted with the latest splash screen—not the best, but certainly much better than its previous version. I always felt that if a bigger and wider splash were added by default, like Photoshop [PS], it would provide a more aesthetic feel. Unlike other image editing applications, GIMP's hardware resource expectations aren't that high, and likewise the application is quite responsive despite being one of the most feature rich editors.

The first thing you will notice about GIMP is its rejuvenated interface. Yes, it has finally gone through some UI changes. A new permanent 'empty' window will appear next to the toolbox and layer box. In addition to this, the toolbox, layer box, and active image editing window list has been merged into one window list, making GIMP more aesthetically appealing.

Apart from that, the current UI changes are too minimal and experimental—it seems developers were uncertain about what to implement and what not to. The current UI development indicates that developers intend to evoke community feedback for further UI development.

On the templates front, GIMP hasn't added new window sizes and ratios, and it would have been a welcome change if the developers had added the HD template by default.

In a nutshell, it's the tools, plug-ins and the core that have witnessed a major facelift. With the inception of GEGL, a few new image editing plug-ins and enhanced editing tools are now available.

We'll take a look at some of these new additions.

Polygon selection tool

The most exquisite feature of GIMP is the polygon selection tool, an add-on to the existing free-hand selection tool. Unlike the earlier versions, this tool lets you select/outline an image or its part in multiple clicks. Previously, you couldn't perform this function completely if you took your finger off the mouse, mid-click. So, in order to select/outline a part, you had to complete it at one go, else it wouldn't be done.

Brush dynamics

Brush dynamics is another value-added plug-in. The latest version now has added extensions to the brush tool—viz., Velocity, Pressure and Random. You can create different styles using similar brushes by varying the speed, although this option is aimed at users owning a pen and tablet. Each of the above mentioned parameters can be further enhanced by opacity, hardness, size and colour.

An enhanced text tool

The new text tool lets you frame your text into a box, and then you can move/resize it at will. This function is useful for large text editing, though you have to edit the text in a different window. On-canvas text editing has been planned for GIMP 2.8.



Figure 1: The new interface

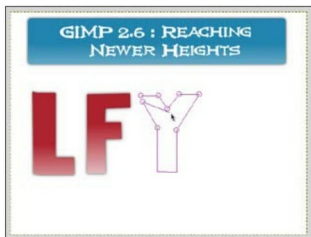


Figure 2: Polygon free selection tool

The ability to pan beyond the border

This feature lets you use the brush tool at the edge of the image while the image is being zoomed in. The feature provides precise control over the brush tool making it much easier for you to control even at high zooms.

GEGL operations and tools

The talk of the town is, however, GIMP's GEGL integration. As already mentioned, GEGL supports high-end graph-based editing with 32-bit colour channel support. And although version 2.6 carries the GEGL tag with honour, is GEGL integration really worth it? No! There are many reasons GEGL doesn't make version 2.6 much better than 2.4 because the developers haven't



Figure 3: Brush dynamics